

A Paraiyar couple from an album of sketches of South Indian costumes, 1843.

But the Nadars or Shanars were by no means at the bottom of the social scale, because below them, and considered by them to be vastly inferior, were a community known to Caldwell as ‘Pareiyas and Pullers [more correctly, Mallas], the hereditary slaves of the wealthier classes’.

The name of this unfortunate underclass – spelled by Caldwell and others in a variety of ways, but let us stick with ‘Paraiyar’ – had already by Caldwell’s time become synonymous with ‘outcaste’ in the word ‘pariah’. This most unfair branding goes right back to the days of Francis Day of